



▲ Nara actress

This figurine wears a replica of a costume worn by an actress from the musical theater of the Japanese Nara Court (710–794 CE). The music performed at court was influenced by that of China's Tang Dynasty.

THROUGH THE AGES

The stage

Women's roles in the history of theater have varied across cultures. Even when societies allowed women to tread the boards, most producers and writers tended to be men. Today, this inequality still persists.

FEW OF THE GREATEST female roles of all time were written for women. Male actors, often young boys, played female roles from classical times, and iconic female parts—from Sophocles' *Electra* to Shakespeare's *Lady Macbeth*—were written for men. In Europe, the

Church forbade women from appearing on stage until the Reformation, when papal authority was challenged. Women were finally allowed on stage in Spain in the 16th century, and early in the 17th century, Cervantes described a company of actors with a female lead in his novel *Don Quixote*. At the end of the 16th century, an actress named Marie Vernier starred in plays in France.

In England, playhouses were closed by the puritanical Oliver Cromwell after the Civil War of the 17th century, and did not reopen until restoration of the monarchy in 1660. Theater-loving Charles II granted royal

patents and women were invited to perform. The first English stage actress was Margaret Hughes, who in 1660 played Desdemona in Shakespeare's *Othello*. New “breeches” roles also enabled actresses to dress up as men. Female playwrights, too, found success at this time; Aphra Behn's first play, *The Forced Marriage*, premiered in 1670.

In Asia, it was very different. Female theater groups are cited in Indian epics, the *Mahabharata* and *Ramayana*, and a treatise called the *Natyasastra* describes an all-female dramatic performance known as *lasyam*. There were no rules against female actors in the Sanskrit dramas at the end of the 7th century. Companies could be all male, all female, or mixed. When Islam started to spread eastward in the 10th and 11th centuries, however, the theater was discouraged. In China, although

“The **roles for women in theater** are much **better** than they are in **film**.”

KIM CATTRALL, ACTRESS, 2011

